

UPSC COMPREHENSIVE NOTES: TRADE, FINANCE, & DIGITAL RULES (APRIL 2026)

INDIA - NEW ZEALAND FREE TRADE AGREEMENT (FTA)

① KEY FEATURES:

- FTA DUTY FREE ACCESS FOR 100% INDIA EXPORTS TO NZ.
- 95% TARIFF REMOVAL (on both sides, over time).
- NZ COMMIT TO INVEST USD 20 BILLION OVER 15 YEARS.



② SKILLED MOBILITY: FTA OPENS SKILLED EMPLOYMENT PATHWAYS.

- QUOTA: 5000 VISAS PER YEAR.



③ AGREEMENT DETAILS:

- GI TAG RECOGNITION (e.g., Darjeeling Tea).
- DUTY FREE ACCESS FOR WINE (NZ to India, staged).
- EXPORTS: AG PRODUCTS, SHEEP MEAT, SENSITIVE GOODS.



④ STRATEGIC IMPACT: DEEPENS ASIA PACIFIC TRADE ARCHITECTURE.

- EXCLUSIONS: DAIRY ANIMAL PRODUCTS (PROTECTED BY INDIA).



RBI TIGHTENS BAD LOAN RULES & PROVISIONING (ALIGNING WITH GLOBAL NORMS)

① OBJECTIVE: PREVENT NPA BUILDUP. STRENGTHEN FINANCIAL SYSTEM.



② DEFINITION: NPA CLASSIFICATION - 90 DAYS OVERDUE.



③ MAJOR CHANGE: ADOPTION OF EXPECTED CREDIT LOSS (ECL) FRAMEWORK (vs. Incurred Loss).



- THREE STAGE CLASSIFICATION BASED ON CREDIT RISK (NOT JUST TIME)

④ IMPLEMENTATION: BORROWER LEVEL NPA TAGGING

(Default on one loan affects all loans).

- AUTOMATED RECOGNITION.



⑤ PROVISIONING FLOORS: MINIMUM RESERVES SET FOR EACH STAGE.

DRAFT AMENDMENTS TO INDIA'S INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY RULES 2026

① KEY CHANGE: RE-EVALUATING "SAFE HARBOUR" PROTECTION (Liability for Intermediaries).



② CONSTITUTIONAL CONCERNS: IMPACT ON ART 19(1)(A) (Freedom of Speech and Expression). GOVERNANCE OF ONLINE SPEECH.



FREE
SPEECH

③ CRITICISMS: POTENTIAL FOR EXECUTIVE OVERREACH. RESTRICTIONS ON DIGITAL FREEDOMS.



GOVERNMENT
CONTROL

④ OBLIGATIONS: STRICTER DATA RETENTION OBLIGATIONS. CONCERNS OF STATE CONTROL.



⑤ THE BALANCE: ENSURING ACCOUNTABILITY VS. PRESERVING OPEN INTERNET.

WAY FORWARD: ROBUST SAFEGUARDS, JUDICIAL OVERSIGHT.



UPSC PRELIMS & MAINS 2026 QUICK REVISION NOTEBOOK



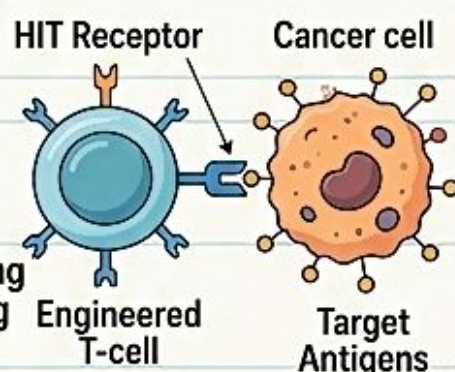
SCIENCE & TECH: REVOLUTIONIZING CANCER THERAPY

1. CART T-CELL THERAPY FOR SOLID TUMOURS

- CAR T-Cell therapy is a landmark for blood cancers but challenged by **SOLID TUMOURS**

2. KEY INNOVATIONS

- A breakthrough is the **HIT RECEPTOR (HLA-INDEPENDENT T-CELL)** to combat **PSEUDO HETEROGENEITY** (low antigen expression)
- HIT receptors engage natural activation, enabling **T-CELLS TO ELIMINATE TUMOURS** by detecting low-density proteins (e.g., CD70)
- Overcomes antigen-negative relapses, enhancing efficacy in ovarian, pancreatic, and kidney cancers



INFRASTRUCTURE: INDIA'S DIGITAL & AI GROWTH

GOOGLE AI DATA HUB IN INDIA

- Google's major AI data centre expansion with gigawatt-scale hubs (e.g., Vizag Campus with Adani Group)
- AIMs for total capacity approaching 1 GW across multiple campuses



SIGNIFICANCE

- Features: New state-of-the-art facilities, direct linkage to **AMERICA-INDIA CONNECT** subsea cable, and massive training infrastructure
- STRENGTHENS** India's position as a global AI powerhouse with reliable, secure data storage and processing
- Tied to green power projects

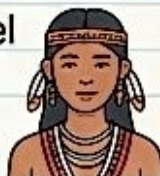


POLITY & CULTURE: TRIBE AND IDENTITY

B'NEI MENASHE COMMUNITY

CONTEXT

- MIZO** and **KUKI TRIBES** in Northeast India (Manipur & Mizoram)
- Known as "**B'NEI MENASHE**" (Sons of Manasseh)
- Part of "**JEUSE**" or related groups claim ancient connection to Israel
- Trace roots to the "**LOST TRIBE OF ISRAEL**" (Manasseh)
- Movement of **ALIYAH** (immigration to Israel), with thousands moving and adopting Jewish faith
- Intersections of tribal identity, ancient claims, and modern migration laws



ENVIRONMENT: ECOLOGY & CHALLENGES



SESSHACHALAM FOREST / EASTERN GHATS

RECENT INCIDENTS

- Located in Andhra Pradesh, India, part of Eastern Ghats
- Designated as India's **FIRST BIOSPHERE RESERVE** (in some definitions, a **BIOSPHERE RESERVE** (first in AP, important globally))
- DRY DECIDUOUS FOREST** ecosystem
- Home to rare **RED SANDERS** (endemic species), global demand and key flora
- KEY FAUNA** includes Slender Loris, Golden Gecko, and Giant Squirrel
- Indigenous **YANADI TRIBE** with unique traditions
- Recent **BLAZES**/forest fires in the region (e.g., April 2026), threatening biodiversity and red sanders

